MODULE 14 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Communication strategy

How communication works, choosing methods, planning who needs what, the channels formula, listening, meetings and feedback loops.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 14 of 49

admin@sthithapragna.com

Communication is not what you send. It is **what is understood**.

The basic communication model

01

Encode

The sender turns thoughts into words, images or data.

02

Transmit

Through a medium: email, call, meeting, board.

03

Noise

Anything that distorts it: jargon, culture, distraction.

04

Decode

The receiver interprets it through their own context.

05

Feedback

The receiver confirms what they understood.

ON THE EXAM

Without feedback, the sender cannot know whether the message arrived as meant.

Acknowledgement is not understanding

- The **sender** is responsible for making the message clear, and for checking it was understood.
- The **receiver** is responsible for receiving it fully and acknowledging it.
- 'Received, thanks' means the message arrived. It does not mean it was understood, or agreed.
- For important messages, check understanding: ask for a summary, or discuss the implications.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Acknowledgement means 'I got it'. It does not mean 'I understood' and it certainly does not mean 'I agree'.

Three communication methods

METHOD	EXAMPLES	BEST FOR
Interactive	Meetings, calls, workshops, video conferences	Complex, urgent or sensitive topics; decisions; confirming understanding
Push	Emails, memos, reports, notifications	Specific recipients who need the information, where no discussion is needed
Pull	Intranet, shared drives, dashboards, knowledge bases	Large audiences, or reference information people find when they need it

ON THE EXAM

Push confirms delivery, not understanding. When understanding matters, choose interactive.

Analysing communication requirements

- **Who** needs information, and **what** exactly do they need?
- **Why** do they need it: to decide, to act, or to be aware?
- **When** and how often, and in what **format and level of detail**?
- Tailor to the stakeholder: executives want decisions and exceptions; teams want detail.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Start from what each stakeholder needs to do with the information. Then choose format and frequency.

The communications management plan

IT RECORDS	FOR EXAMPLE
Stakeholder requirements	What each stakeholder or group needs to know, and why
Information and format	Status summary, risk report, decision log; level of detail
Method and technology	Meeting, email, dashboard; which tools
Timing and frequency	Weekly, per sprint, at milestones, on exception
Responsibilities	Who sends, who approves, who receives
Escalation and glossary	How issues escalate; shared terms defined

ON THE EXAM

A communications plan is a living document. When a stakeholder's needs change, the plan changes.

The channels formula

- **Channels = n x (n - 1) / 2**, where n is the number of people.
- 5 people: 5 x 4 / 2 = **10** channels. 10 people: 10 x 9 / 2 = **45**.
- Grow from 10 to 13 people: 78 - 45 = **33 more** channels, from just 3 new people.
- Include the project manager in n. Read whether the question asks for the total or the increase.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Channels grow much faster than headcount. That is why adding people adds communication overhead.

Dimensions of communication

DIMENSION	EXAMPLES
Formal or informal	A contract notice, or a corridor chat
Written or oral	A report, or a briefing
Internal or external	The team, or a client or regulator
Upward, downward, sideways	To the sponsor, to the team, to peer managers
Official or unofficial	An approved status report, or an off-the-record conversation

ON THE EXAM

Contracts, legal notices and formal decisions are formal and written. Relationships are built informally.

Active listening

- **Attend** fully: no laptop, no phone, no rehearsing your reply.
- **Paraphrase**: 'So what you are saying is...'
- Ask **clarifying questions** before offering solutions.
- **Summarise** agreements and next steps at the end.
- Interrupting to fix the problem tells people you were not really listening.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Paraphrasing is the feedback loop inside a conversation. Use it for anything that matters.

Meetings that earn their time

- A clear **purpose** and **agenda**, shared in advance.
- Only the **people needed** for the decisions or discussion.
- A **timebox**, a facilitator, and decisions and actions recorded with owners.
- Status that could be read should not be read aloud. Move it to a report or dashboard.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Meet to discuss and decide. Inform through pull and push. Large status read-outs waste everyone's time.

Establishing a feedback loop

- The outline asks you to **establish a feedback loop** in your communication.
- Ask stakeholders whether they get what they need, in the form they need it.
- Short surveys, a question at the end of reviews, or a communications item in retrospectives.
- Watch the signals: unread reports, repeated questions, surprises at reviews.
- Then **adjust the plan**. Feedback nobody acts on is not a loop.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If you do not know whether your communication works, you have not closed the loop. Ask, then adapt.

Transparency and collaboration

- **Information radiators**: visible boards and charts anyone can see without asking.
- Open backlogs, shared channels and decision logs, available to everyone who needs them.
- **Osmotic communication**: co-located teams overhear useful information. Distributed teams must recreate it deliberately.
- Transparency is the first pillar of empiricism. It is what makes inspection possible.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Make information easy to find without asking. That is the most scalable communication there is.

What blocks communication

- **Jargon and acronyms** the receiver does not share.
- **Information overload**: so much sent that the important item is missed.
- **Wrong channel**: sensitive news by email, a decision in a chat thread.
- **Cultural and language differences**, and assumptions about shared context.
- Each blocker has a fix: plain language, tailoring, the right channel, and checking understanding.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> When communication fails, look for the blocker before sending more.

Project Lantern: the communications plan in brief

- **Steering committee**: one-page exception report every fortnight; decisions requested in advance.
- **Clinic managers**: a go-live briefing meeting per clinic, then a weekly readiness checklist.
- **Reception staff**: short demonstration sessions with questions, plus a pull knowledge base.
- **Everyone**: a project dashboard, updated automatically, and a monthly two-question feedback survey.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Different stakeholders, different methods and frequencies, all from one plan, with a feedback loop built in.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Team size changes; how many channels?	n(n-1)/2; check total or increase
Stakeholder gets too much of the wrong thing	Revisit their requirements; update the plan
Understanding must be confirmed	Interactive, not push or pull
'Received' but acted on old information	Check understanding, not just delivery
Long status meetings, low engagement	Status to dashboards; meetings for decisions
No idea if reports are useful	Establish a feedback loop, then adjust

ON THE EXAM

Communication succeeds when the right person understands the right thing in time. Design for that.

> A project team has eight members, including the project manager. To meet a new deadline, four more people join the team.
>
> The project manager is concerned about the extra communication effort.

How many additional communication channels does the change create?

A 4

B 38

C 66

D 28

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How many additional communication channels does the change create?

A 4

Counts people, not channels.

B 38

12 x 11 / 2 = 66, minus 8 x 7 / 2 = 28, gives 38 additional.

C 66

The new total. The question asked for the increase.

D 28

The original total, before anyone joined.

THE SIGNAL

Compute both totals, then subtract. 'Additional' and 'total' are different answers, and both appear as options.

> A regional director complains that she receives every weekly team report and every meeting invitation for a project, which she has no time to read.
>
> Yet she was surprised last week by a decision that affects her region's budget.

What should the project manager do?

A Reduce the number of reports sent to all stakeholders.

B Add an executive summary to the top of every weekly report.

C Continue as now, since she already receives all the information.

D Review her communication requirements with her, and update the communications plan.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Cut reports for everyone.

One stakeholder's problem, fixed by changing everyone's communication.

B Executive summaries everywhere.

Helps a little, but still buries the decision she needed among everything else.

C Carry on.

She received everything and still missed what mattered. That is the failure.

D Review her requirements; update the plan.

Tailors to what she actually needs: fewer reports, and decisions affecting her region.

THE SIGNAL

Too much of the wrong thing and too little of the right thing: the plan does not match her needs.

> A new safety procedure for operating a crane comes into force on a construction site next Monday.
>
> Every crane operator and banksman must understand it, and the site manager needs confirmation that they do.

Which communication method should the project manager use?

A Briefing sessions with demonstrations and questions, confirming each person's understanding.

B An email to every operator with the procedure attached.

C Publish the procedure on the site intranet.

D Post the procedure on the site noticeboard.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which communication method should the project manager use?

A Interactive briefings, confirming understanding.

Safety-critical and understanding must be confirmed: interactive.

B Email.

Push: confirms delivery at best, never understanding.

C Intranet.

Pull: relies on each person choosing to read it.

D Noticeboard.

Pull again, and the weakest check of all.

THE SIGNAL

When understanding must be confirmed, and especially for safety, communicate interactively.

> The project manager emailed a design change to a supplier's lead engineer. He replied 'Received, thanks'.
>
> Two weeks later, the supplier delivers parts built to the old design.

What should the project manager have done?

A Resent the email with a read receipt requested.

B Copied the engineer's manager on the email.

C Confirmed understanding, for example by discussing the change and asking him to summarise its impact.

D Relied on the reply, since the engineer acknowledged the change.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager have done?

A Read receipt.

Proves opening, not understanding. The same failure, better documented.

B Copy his manager.

More recipients, no more understanding.

C Confirm understanding.

The sender's responsibility: check the message was understood, not just received.

D Rely on the reply.

That is exactly what happened. Acknowledgement is not understanding.

THE SIGNAL

'Received, thanks' is acknowledgement. For a critical change, the sender must confirm understanding.

A weekly two-hour status meeting has twenty-five attendees. Each workstream lead reads out an update, and most attendees work on laptops.

Several stakeholders say the meeting wastes their time, but they fear missing something important.

What should the project manager do?

A Make attendance mandatory and ban laptops.

B Extend the meeting so every update can be discussed.

C Cancel all project meetings and rely on email.

D Move updates to a shared dashboard, and keep a shorter meeting for decisions with the people needed.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Mandatory, no laptops.
Enforces attention on a format that wastes it.

B Extend the meeting.
More of what is already not working.

C Email only.
Loses discussion and decisions entirely.

D Dashboard for status; short decision meeting.
Status becomes pull; the meeting is kept for what needs people live.

THE SIGNAL

Status read aloud to a crowd is the wrong method. Pull for status, interactive for decisions.

> For six months, a project manager has sent a detailed monthly newsletter to all stakeholders. Nobody has ever replied.
>
> The project manager has no idea whether anyone reads it or finds it useful.

What should the project manager do?

A Keep sending it, since nobody has complained.

B Ask key stakeholders for feedback, for example with a short survey, and adjust based on the answers.

C Send it weekly instead, to increase its visibility.

D Stop sending it, since nobody replies.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Keep going.
Silence is not evidence of value. The loop is still open.

B Ask for feedback; adjust.
Establishes the feedback loop the outline asks for.

C Send it weekly.
Four times the output, with no idea whether any of it helps.

D Stop it.
A guess in the other direction. Some stakeholders may rely on it.

THE SIGNAL

No idea whether it works: the feedback loop is missing. Ask, then adapt.

Plan for understanding, not delivery. Then close the loop.